The Math Curse

By Jon Scieszka

INTRODUCTION

Did you ever wake up to one of those days where everything is a problem? You have ten things to do, but only thirty minutes until your bus leaves. Is there enough time? You have three shirts and two pairs of pants. Can you make one good outfit? Then you start to wonder: Why does everything have to be such a problem? Why do two apples always have to be added to five oranges? Why do four kids always have to divide twelve marbles? Why can't you just keep ten cookies without someone taking three away? Why? Because you're the victim of . . .

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NARRATOR: On Monday in math class, Mrs. Fibonacci says

MRS. FIBONACCI: You know, you can think of almost everything as a math problem.

NARRATOR: On Tuesday I start having problems. I wake up at 7:15. It takes me ten minutes to get dressed, fifteen minutes to eat my breakfast, and one minute to brush my teeth. Suddenly, it's a problem: If my bus leaves at 8:00, will I make it on time? How many minutes in one hour? How many teeth in one mouth?

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I'm getting a little worried. Everything seems to be a problem.

I take the milk out for my cereal and wonder: How many quarts in a gallon? How many pints in a quart? How many inches in a foot? How many feet in a yard? How many yards in a neighborhood? How many inches in a pint? How many feet in my shoes?

I don't even bother to take out the cereal. I don't want to know how many flakes in a bowl.

Mrs. Fibonacci has obviously put a MATH CURSE on me. Everything I look at or think about has become a math problem.

I TRY to get on the bus without thinking about anything, but there are five kids already on the bus, five kids get on at my stop, five more get on at the next stop, and five MORE get on at the last stop. True or false: What is the bus driver's name?

Mrs. Fibonacci has this chart of what month everyone's birthday is in: Which month has the most birthdays? Which month has the fewest? Why doesn't February

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have a *w*? Do you ever look at clouds and think they look like something else?

The whole morning is one problem after another. There are 24 kids in my class. I just know someone is going to bring in cupcakes to share. We sit in four rows with six desks in each row. What if Mrs. Fibonacci rearranges the desks to make six rows? Eight rows? Three rows? Two rows? I count the 24 kids in our class again, this time by two's.

Jake scratches his paper with one finger. How many fingers are in our class? Casey pulls Eric's ear. How many ears are in our class? The new girl, Kelly, sticks her tongue out at me. How many tongues in our class? I'm about to really lose it, when the lunch bell rings.

Unfortunately for me, lunch is pizza and apple pie. Each pizza is cut into eight equal slices. Each pie is cut into six equal slices. And you know what that means: fractions. If I want two slices of pizza should I ask for: one-eighth? Two-eighths? Or two slices of pizza? What is another way to say one half of an apple pie? Two-sixths? Three-sixths? Or la moitiė d'une tarte aux pommes? Which

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tastes greater? Half a pizza, or half an apple pie? We haven't studied fractions yet, so I take twelve carrot sticks three at a time and eat them two at a time.

In the afternoon, every subject is a problem. Social studies is a geography problem. The Mississippi River is about four thousand kilometers long. An M&M is about one centimeter long. There are one hundred centimeters in a meter, and one thousand meters in a kilometer. Estimate how many M&Ms it would take to measure the length of the Mississippi River. Estimate how many M&Ms you would eat if you had to measure the Mississippi River with M&Ms. Bonus: Can you spell Mississippi without any M&Ms?

English is a word problem. If mail plus box equals mailbox: Does lipstick minus stick equal lip? Does tunafish plus tunafish equal fournafish?

Physical education is a sports problem. In 1919, Babe Ruth hit 29 home runs, batted .322, and made $40,000. In 1991, the average major league baseball player hit fifteen home runs, batted .275, and made $840,000. circle the correct answer: Babe Ruth is less than the

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average modern baseball player, Babe Ruth is greater than the average modern baseball player, or Babe Ruth is equal to the average modern baseball player.

Math is just a total problem. Mrs. Fibonacci says there are many ways to count. She asks us to give some examples.

RUSSELL: *(counting on his fingers)* 1,2,3,4,5,6,7,8,9,10.

MOLLY: 2,4,6,8,10…

MRS. FIBONACCI: I always count 1,1,2,3,5,8,13. . . But on the planet Tetra, kids have only two fingers on each hand. They count 1,2,3,10. . . And on the planet Binary, kids have only one finger on each hand. They count 1,10 . . .

NARRATOR: Do you think Mrs. Fibonacci has been to the planet Tetra? How would you bowl if you lived on the planet Binary?

We are just about to go home when Rebecca remembers the special birthday cupcakes her mom made. There are 24 kids in the class. Rebecca has 24 cupcakes. So what's the problem? Rebecca wants Mrs. Fibonacci to have a cupcake, too. Everyone is going crazy trying to figure out

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what fraction of a cupcake each person will get. I'm the first to figure out the answer. I raise my hand and tell Mrs. Fibonacci I'm allergic to cupcakes. Everyone (24) believes me and gets one (1) cupcake. No one (0) has to figure out fractions.

I stagger out of school. I'm a math zombie now. I have to find something to break this math curse. I decide to try chocolate. My favorite candy bar is usually fifty cents. But guess what? Today it's on sale for 50% off. I decide to buy licorice instead.

I pull out my money. I have a five-dollar bill, a one-dollar bill, a quarter, and a penny. George Washington is on both the quarter and the one-dollar bill. Abraham Lincoln is on both the penny and the five-dollar bill. So which is true? One Washington equals 25 Lincolns, five Washingtons equal one Lincoln, one Washington equals one hundred Lincolns, or one Lincoln equals twenty Washingtons? Don't forget to show your work. Extra credit: How do you think Thomas Jefferson feels about all of this?

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I am now a raving math lunatic. What if this keeps up for a whole year? How many minutes of math madness would that be?

SISTER: What's your problem?

NARRATOR: *(snarling)* 365 days times 24 hours times 60 minutes! *(to audience)* Dinner brings no relief. While passing the mashed potatoes, Mom says . . .

MOM: What your father says is false.

NARRATOR: Dad helps himself to some potatoes and says,

DAD: What your mother says is true.

NARRATOR: I think about that for a minute. If what Mom says is true, then what Dad says is false. But if what Dad says is false, then what Mom says isn't true. And if what Mom says isn't true, then what Dad says isn't false. But that can't be true because he says that what Mom says is true, and she says that what he says is false.

Can that be true? I think about that. Then I think about it some more. Then I think I'd better go to bed.

I undo eight buttons plus two shoelaces. I subtract two shoes. I multiply times two socks and divide by three

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pillows to get five sheep, remainder one, which is all I need to count before I fall asleep.

Then the problems really begin.

I dream I'm trapped in a room with no doors and no windows. The room is covered with a lifetime of problems. I have only one piece of chalk. How do I get out? I'm about to give up and die, when the answer to my problem comes to me. Fractions. I break the chalk in half. Then I put the two halves together. One half plus one half equals one whole. I put the hole on the wall and jump out. I'm free.

I wake up Wednesday morning at 7:15. It takes me ten minutes to get dressed, fifteen minutes to eat my breakfast, and one minute to brush my teeth. My bus leaves at 8:00. What time will I be ready? 7:41. No problem.

I've broken the math curse. I can solve any problem. And life is just great until science class, when Mr. Newton says,

MR. NEWTON: You know, you can think of almost everything as a science experiment. . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
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